

do their own thing. You can guarantee that they won't be able to keep their ecosystem walled up for too long though.

This could very well apply to gaming PCs, and all hardware you game on in the long run. Eventually, there will come a time where all you need is a great display and your controller of choice. All of this will be possible when what we're going to talk about next becomes mainstream.

Gaming on the cloud

We are on the cusp of cloud gaming, and we can already see a lot of the big wigs in the industry working on various cloud-based gaming services. You've got Sony's PS Now, Microsoft's Xbox Cloud Gaming, Nvidia's GeForce Now and Google's Stadia to name a few. Our transition to digital began a while ago, when we moved to a primarily digital means of distribution over physical copies.

The idea behind cloud gaming is to have the game running on the cloud and stream it directly on to your device. This has a lot of advantages, like we mentioned in the previous section it would do away with consoles and the need for gaming hardware entirely. This automatically drastically drops the price of getting into gaming, and makes it even more accessible to the masses. The biggest hurdle is setting up the infrastructure required to make it all work, i.e., servers and such, and of course, having an internet connection fast enough to actually support cloud gaming. A lot of places in India already have access to high-speed internet, however, a lot of our connections have quotas, which cloud gaming would blow through in just a few hours depending on the quality.

The benefits of cloud gaming don't end there though. It's a major boon to game developers as well, who will no longer need to worry about developing multiple versions of their game. There will be a single version that works across all devices, a single version that's easy to patch and fix; patches and fixes which can be deployed almost instantly.

VR, AR

For a while now VR was touted to be the next big thing in gaming, however it hasn't quite taken off because of a number of barriers. The headsets are heavy, they're a tangled mess of wires, they're expensive, they're a pain to set up and use etc. Of course, all of this will change and is already changing. There are already wire-free headsets but they're still not something that one could consider affordable. There's the additional fact that you needed a beast of a PC just to use VR. All of this means that it'll be a while

When you talk about VR, the next thing that always comes up is AR or Augmented Reality. The idea of augmented reality is overlaying digital objects over a person's field of view. The AR most of us are familiar with is geo-based AR, the kind we've seen in Pokemon Go. This kind of AR has been around for a while though. Innovation in AR would mean more interactive and varying AR experiences, experiences where people could play something like laser tag indoors without needing any more equipment than the AR lenses themselves.



VR and AR will grow consistently as hardware gets cheaper and more powerful

before VR or Virtual Reality is truly mainstream. The potential applications of VR don't just end at VR games though, once Virtual Reality headsets are at a stage where anyone can comfortably wear them for long periods of time, there's nothing stopping them from being used for non-VR experiences and games as well. VR controls would need to be overhauled but the possibilities are quite exciting. Imagine having your headset on while chilling on a sofa, being able to freely look around in your game. Or imagine playing a real-time strategy game and being able to stand on the map as you command your armies. All of this might still be further beyond the next 20 years though.

Artificial Intelligence

AI or Artificial Intelligence is something that relies on computational power. What was once something that was used only in the most powerful of supercomputers, is slowly being adapted into various fields, including gaming. This of course is thanks to how fast technology and hardware has been evolving over the last few years. AI is already used in gaming today, the now redeemed No Man's Sky for example, uses a generative machine learning algorithm that creates all the new planets that you explore in the universe, and the diverse flora and fauna you encounter on them as well. FromSoftware's Dark Souls also utilises AI to make their game harder. They obviously succeeded. Many of